Hope

Written by

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1 INT. FRONT-DOOR - NIGHT 1

CHLOE (22), looking rumpled and buzzed in a party dress with MARK's oversized black bomber jacket slipping from her shoulders, leans heavily against MARK as he opens the door. MARK (22), looking tired but holding it together in his tie-dye shirt, follows her through.

CHLOE
(In a mock royal voice)
Your grandest caffeine on rocks my fine fellow!

MARK
(returning the energy)
Of course darling! Anything to wrench the Smirnoff from thy system.

He takes her jacket. She lets it drop halfway to the floor.

MARK exhales, moves toward the kitchen. She crashes onto the couch, phone in hand, legs hanging off the armrest.

CHLOE
Do you think it is too early to text Leo?

2 INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS 2

MARK’s back stiffens. He opens the fridge, staring inside longer than necessary.

MARK
(Voice tight)
Leo?

CHLOE
(Excitedly, throwing her hands up)
OMG Leo! Did you meet him MARK? The hunk of all good I met at that party. He was so, intense. He actually listened when I talked about my work. Like, really listened, you know?

MARK slowly starts pouring milk into the tall glasses.

MARK
(Without turning)
I was there, CHLOE. I saw him.

CHLOE
Right! He even asked if we were together, and I said... well, we're apartment buddies. Besties since seventh grade.

MARK's hand freezes mid-pour. The stream of milk cuts off sharply.

MARK
(quiet, even)
You're ashamed to be seen with me?

CHLOE
What? No! I just... told the truth. Is that a crime?

MARK adds the ice to the tall glasses as a hard laugh escapes him.

MARK
The trust. Right.

CHLOE's smile falters.

MARK (cont'd)
You know, he asked about you... and I found myself saying all these things. How amazing you are. How I'd do anything for you-

CHLOE
MARK. Don't. You're making things weird.

MARK sighs as he walks out of the kitchen.

3 INT. LIVING ROOM — CONTINUOUS 3

MARK walks in with two glasses of iced coffee. Eyes locked on the glasses, unable to meet her gaze. CHLOE sits up to make room for him. He hands one of the glasses to her and sits close.

MARK
(deliberately bright, a false normalcy)
Here you go, hon.

She smiles entertained, shaking her head.

CHLOE
Don’t start with that “hon” crap now too. Be normal for once, I beg.

MARK
Too bad. Not when you look like that.

Her grin falters. The air shifts.

CHLOE
(apprehensive)
MARK…

MARK
(Quiet)
You think this is fair? You get to laugh it off, flirt with whoever, and I’m supposed to sit here pretending I’m fine?

CHLOE shakes her head.

CHLOE
You’re blowing this way out of proportion, MARK. It’s not a thing. We’re talking about ten seconds at a party.

MARK
It’s not about those ten seconds at the party. It’s about the ten years leading up to... this.

CHLOE
It’s not like that.

MARK
Then what is it like?

He leans forward, elbows on his knees. She stares at her coffee, but doesn’t drink.

She reaches to put her hand over his on his knee.

MARK pulls his knee away.

MARK (cont’d)
Don’t!. You’ll just hurt me more. Don’t give me... hope, CHLOE.

CHLOE’s eyes flick up, startled by the sharpness in his voice. She sets her glass down, locking eyes with it, hands trembling slightly.

CHLOE
(tears in her voice)
I don't want to hurt you anymore.

She leans forward, looks back up at MARK and searches his face, trying to make him see her honesty.

CHLOE (cont'd)
I wish I could. I just... don't know how.

MARK leans back, eyes wet, jaw tight. He exhales through his nose.

The refrigerator hums somewhere in the background.

MARK
Then tell me what you do know?
Because right now, I just know hurt.

CHLOE opens her mouth, but no words come. Her hands twist in her lap.

CHLOE
I know I care about you... I know, you expect me to say the right words. But I know my words don't mean much right now though.

A heavy silence. He studies her face, searching for truth.

MARK
(softly)
Then show me.

She freezes.

CHLOE
MARK... what are you saying?

MARK
Show me, CHLOE.
If any of this means something to you, show me.

She doesn't move.

CHLOE
MARK... please.

MARK
Kiss me.

CHLOE throws her head back in anger/exasperation.

CHLOE
(insulted)
I can’t believe you would try to force this.

MARK
What else do you want!? I’m TIRED of waiting, CHLOE. Waiting... and watching. Watching you get used and hurt. But me... I’ve been hurting for ten fucking years.

CHLOE
And you think I haven’t been waiting too? Do you think this-

CHLOE gestures at their shared space.

CHLOE (cont’d)
And this-

She gestures "at" the connection between them.

CHLOE (cont’d)
I’m trying to be careful, MARK, because I care about you.

CHLOE avoids his gaze as she looks at the coffee on the table.

MARK
Careful? Is that what this is? I don’t feel very cared for! I feel... hurt.

CHLOE’s hand clumsily rakes for MARK’s, then retracts as if burned.

CHLOE
I know, and that’s the last thing I want.

MARK crosses his arms.

MARK
What do you want CHLOE? Because I don’t understand what you want from me anymore.

CHLOE runs her hands through her hair as she groans.

CHLOE
I want you to see that this isn't easy for me either. Can't you see I'm trying to figure all of this out?

CHLOE gestures at the living room.

MARK
What am I supposed to do? While you figure all of this out? Am I supposed to ignore that when you smile. It's not like watching sunlight touch water. So warm, endless, impossible to ignore. I mean fuck! I could drown in that, I would drown in it. But instead, am I just supposed to stay here? Like this-

He gestures to the two of them.

MARK (cont'd)
Whatever this is... isn't happening? I can't hide anymore. I'm fucking tired of hiding!

CHLOE stands up quickly.

CHLOE
Fuck! I'm trying okay? I'm trying to figure things out, but you yelling isn't exactly making it any easier MARK!

MARK
(pleading)
Then talk to me CHLOE! I'm right here, tell me what you're thinking. Instead of shutting me all out.

CHLOE
I don't know what to tell you! Because I know I can't tell you what you want to hear! Okay?! I mean, this is a lot for just one night. I mean, like-

CHLOE tries to rub the tipsiness off her face as she thinks.

CHLOE (cont'd)
What about Leo?

MARK
Leo? Are you serious right now? Really? You want to talk about Leo's feelings right now?

CHLOE shrugs her shoulders.

CHLOE
Well, I don't want to lead him on.

MARK
So, you're worried about leading him on, but not me? What about my feelings, CHLOE? Or do they not matter as much as Romeo's?

CHLOE
That's not fair, MARK, and you know it! This has nothing to do with Leo.

MARK
Then why mention the fucker?

CHLOE
I mentioned him, because I don't want to lead him on! How is that so hard to understand!?

MARK
You know what CHLOE! My bad, you are so right! It's not hard to understand. Of course you care about not leading him on. Fucking hell, you've only been doing it to me for TEN FUCKING YEARS!

CHLOE sits back down and throws her head back against the couch.

CHLOE
(her voice thick with tears)
I'm so sorry MARK! I never meant to hurt you like this.

She reaches out to touch MARK's knee.

He recoils from her touch, his eyes blazing.

MARK
Don't touch me CHLOE! Not when you've been lying to me for ten years!

MARK storms to his room.

MARK (cont'd)
I'm done guessing how you feel. Tell me when you can be honest.

CHLOE
(voice cracking)
MARK— wait.

MARK stops, but doesn't turn.

CHLOE (cont'd)
I don't know what I want. But I promise I'll work through my fears. I can't lose you.
(almost whispers)
MARK...

MARK
(pleading, defeated)
Please... just let me go.

He opens the door and steps inside.

FADE TO BLACK

4 INT. LIVING ROOM - LATER 4

CHLOE sits on the couch watching TV. Her phone lies face down. Her eyes can't help but dart at MARK's bedroom door. She tries to keep her focus on the TV but she just cannot help it.

She hesitates, takes a deep shaky breath and stands.

Slowly, CHLOE steps toward his room, stopping just outside the doorway. She opens the door a crack.

CHLOE
(soft, vulnerable)
I'm here.

5 INT. MARK'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS 5

MARK is lying in bed, facing the wall, his back to the door. He doesn't move at first. Then, he slowly turns, shoulders tense, turning his head just enough to see her.

MARK
I can't trust... this yet.

CHLOE takes a series of small, tentative steps into the room.

CHLOE
I know... But I'll work through it.
Every part of it.

She swallows.

He studies her.

MARK
I'm scared…

She takes the final few steps and gently sits down on the very edge of the bed.

CHLOE
(softly)
Then let me show you.

MARK pushes himself up onto his elbows, then slowly swings his legs to the side of the bed, sitting up. Their faces now inches away.

MARK
(pleading)
Please.

CHLOE looks at his lips then his eyes, slowly nods once, and closes hers.

He leans in just slightly. Their lips meet, soft, brief, a promise more than passion.

MARK pulls back completely. His breathing is shallow.

CHLOE gently catches his face, cupping and caressing his cheek, pulling his forehead to hers.

CHLOE
(whisper)
I'll work through it. I won't hurt
you, I promise.

MARK closes his eyes, slowly nods, leaning into her touch, letting himself believe it all.

FADE OUT